



ON THE WRITE LINE

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INDIA MUST PLAY MORE FIRST-CLASS MATCHES IN PREPARATION FOR OVERSEAS SERIES

The first Test defeat against South Africa is **pretty much** a pattern for Indian teams touring the SENA countries, where they lose the first Test of the series and then play catch-up.

India's defeat in the first Test match against South Africa in Centurion came as a bit of a shock. It was a shock simply because when you looked at the two squads, you found that not only were the Indians more experienced, but they also looked a lot classier in terms of sheer talent. However, what the Test match showed us once again was that temperament is what separated the two teams. The ordinary can do great things if he has the determination to do so, and that's what we saw from almost all the Proteas players.

Not only did Dean Elgar, playing in his last series, show his usual 'khadoos' attitude, but he also shepherded debutant David Bedingham and later Marco Jansen, with whom he had huge partnerships that demoralised the Indians and took the game away. If there was hope that the Indians would learn from Elgar's example, that was extinguished pretty quickly after the Indian skipper, Rohit Sharma, got a beauty from Kagiso Rabada and young Yashasvi Jaiswal a

snorter from Nandre Burger. Though Virat Kohli fought bravely, the others capitulated tamely without much resistance, and that added to the feeling of frustration.

The defeat is pretty much a pattern for Indian teams touring the SENA countries, where they lose the first Test of the series and then play catch-up for the remainder of the series.

The next big series overseas is exactly a year away in Australia, and if India need to keep the winning momentum of the previous two tours there, then the planning must start now. The FTP suggests that India is playing two Tests against Bangladesh and three Tests against New Zealand at home from the end of September to early November.

The first Test of a five-match series in Australia will likely start in early December, so it does give the Indians time to play a couple, if not more, first-class games before the series. Rohit said after the loss in Centurion that these games are no good because the host countries put up second-rate teams, and they get to play